

35 Zipporah

The Midianite wife of Moses who acted quickly in a strange and dangerous night.

Zipporah was one of the seven daughters of Jethro, the priest of Midian. She met Moses when he drove off shepherds who were bullying her and her sisters at a well. Her father gave her to Moses as his wife, and she bore him two sons, Gershom and Eliezer. On the road back to Egypt, when the LORD met Moses and sought to kill him, it was Zipporah who took a flint knife and circumcised their son. Later she was sent back to her father and then brought again to Moses in the wilderness. Scripture says little about her, and several parts of her story are hard to understand. Yet at one crucial moment she saved her husband's life.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Hebrew <i>Tsipporah</i> , meaning "bird"
<i>Family</i>	Daughter of Jethro (Reuel), priest of Midian; one of seven sisters (Exodus 2:16–21)
<i>Husband</i>	Moses (Exodus 2:21)
<i>Sons</i>	Gershom and Eliezer (Exodus 2:22; 18:3–4; 1 Chronicles 23:15)
<i>Key places</i>	Midian, a lodging place on the road to Egypt, the mountain of God
<i>Main passages</i>	Exodus 2:16–22; 4:20–26; 18:2–6
<i>New Testament</i>	Not named

"And Moses was content to dwell with the man: and he gave Moses Zipporah his daughter."

Exodus 2:21, KJV

The life of Zipporah

Zipporah's story is not dated in Scripture. On the early Exodus date, Moses fled to Midian c. 1486 BC and returned to Egypt c. 1446 BC. On the late date, move both about 185 years later.

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| In Midian | ● At the well |
| | She and her sisters come to water their father's flock. Shepherds drive them away, but Moses stands up for them and waters their sheep. <i>Exodus 2:16-19</i> |
| In Midian | ● Married to Moses |
| | Her father invites the stranger home. Moses agrees to stay, and Jethro gives him Zipporah as his wife. <i>Exodus 2:20-21</i> |
| In Midian | ● Mother of Gershom |
| | She bears a son. Moses names him Gershom, saying, "I have been a stranger in a strange land." A second son, Eliezer, is born later. <i>Exodus 2:22; 18:3-4</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>On the road</i> | ● Circumcises her son |
| | Moses sets out for Egypt with his wife and sons on a donkey. At a lodging place the LORD meets him and seeks to kill him. Zipporah circumcises her son, and the LORD lets him go. <i>Exodus 4:20, 24-26</i> |
| Before the
Exodus | ● Sent back |
| | At some point Moses sends Zipporah and the boys back to her father. Scripture does not say when or why. <i>Exodus 18:2</i> |
| c. 1446 BC
<i>Near Sinai</i> | ● Reunited |
| | After Israel leaves Egypt, Jethro brings Zipporah and her two sons to Moses at the mountain of God. <i>Exodus 18:1-6</i> |

Key activities

Exodus 4:24–26 is one of the hardest passages in the Bible. It is unclear whether the LORD sought to kill Moses or his son, whose feet Zipporah touched, and what "a bloody husband" means. Most readers agree the crisis was about the missing sign of the covenant.

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- 1 Worked with her sisters.** She helped water her father's flock and was rescued by Moses at the well. *Exodus 2:16–17*
 - 2 Married a foreigner.** She married Moses, a fugitive who looked like an Egyptian to her family. *Exodus 2:19–21*
 - 3 Raised two sons.** She bore Gershom and Eliezer, whose names recall Moses' life as a stranger and God's help. *Exodus 2:22; 18:3–4*
 - 4 Traveled toward Egypt.** She set out with Moses and the boys on the journey back to Egypt. *Exodus 4:20*
 - 5 Acted in a crisis.** She "took a sharp stone, and cut off the foreskin of her son," and the LORD let Moses go. *Exodus 4:24–26*
 - 6 Returned to Moses.** After a time back with her father, she came to Moses in the wilderness. *Exodus 18:2–6*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Zipporah.

Old Testament

Exodus 2:16–22	She meets and marries Moses
Exodus 4:20–26	The journey to Egypt and her son's circumcision
Exodus 18:2–6	Brought back to Moses in the wilderness
Numbers 12:1	"The Ethiopian woman"; whether this is Zipporah is debated
1 Chronicles 23:14–17	Her sons counted among the Levites

New Testament

Acts 7:29	Moses lived as a stranger in Midian, "where he begat two sons."
Echoes	God commands Joshua to circumcise Israel before they enter the land (Joshua 5:2–9). Paul speaks of circumcision "of the heart" (Romans 2:28–29).

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Zipporah do when the LORD met Moses on the road (Exodus 4:24–26)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God took the sign of the covenant so seriously in the family of Israel's leader?
3. *Apply:* Zipporah acted when her husband could not. When has someone close to you needed you to step in?
4. *Apply:* Is there an act of obedience you have been putting off, as Moses had? What will you do about it this week?